

CHAPTER 2 DISCIPLINE

Core Question: How is man different from animal?

Core Virtue: Discipline

There's a YouTube video I like to watch when I'm feeling unmotivated.

It's a grainy clip from the 2005 documentary *Ronnie Coleman: The Cost of Redemption*. In it, Ronnie Coleman, the 5'11", 300-pound, eight-time Mr. Olympia winner, who is broadly considered the greatest bodybuilder of all time, is getting ready to do some squats.

At first, you don't see Ronnie, you just hear him yell, "lightweight baby!" Then the camera pans over and you see Ronnie standing in front of a bar that is loaded with over 800 pounds. No women and 99.999 percent of men would ever be able to move that weight. We get to hear his pre-lift self-talk.

"I want to do this," he says in a loud voice. Then, with a louder yell a general would use to motivate his troops, he yells, "Everybody wanna be a bodybuilder, don't nobody wanna lift the weight!"

Then, with a tone of resolve, he says, "I do it, though." He unracks the bar, which is bending like a rainbow, and quickly squats it four times with a pain-filled grunt during each rep that sounds more like a lion's roar than a typical human exhale. He reracks the weight and again, but in a calm, normal-speaking voice, says, "lightweight baby."

The video is hilarious because it's ridiculous. The weight is not light. The yells are uncivilized, primal. Obviously, not everybody wants to be a bodybuilder.

COMPETING DESIRES

Ronnie's words speak to a universal truth. Nobody wants to lift this heavy weight, but Ronnie does. Or does he? He's telling himself, "I wanna do this" and at the same time is admitting, "Don't nobody wanna to do this." People want the results, but they don't want the process. There are two incompatible desires in him. Which desire will win out?

I'll half-seriously paraphrase the video and see who identifies:

- Everybody wanna be smart, don't nobody wanna turn these heavy pages.
- Everybody wanna be a homeowner, don't nobody wanna push this heavy mower.
- Everybody wanna be a daddy, don't nobody wanna change these heavy diapers.

- Everybody wanna follow Jesus, don't nobody wanna repent of this heavy sin.
- Everybody wanna be fit, don't nobody wanna stop shoveling these heavy potato chips.

Throughout our days, there is a war going on within every man. The war is a war of desire, a war between our wants. There is what we want, there is what we want to want, and then there is what we should want. Our desires compete with one another.

In the last chapter, we considered how man is a creature. In this chapter, we'll discuss how man is different from the rest of the creatures and what we're supposed to do about that.

DISCIPLINE COMES FROM VISION

Man is the moral animal, which is another way of saying we understand purpose and how it affects our decision-making. We have the ability to order our desires.

You might be familiar with Pavlov's dog. The researcher rings a bell each time he gives the dog a treat, and eventually the dog salivates to the sound of the bell. The dog is not acting with moral vision or even agency; it's merely responding to a stimulus as it's been trained to do.

To treat a man like a dog is to obviously dehumanize him. When a man wants to follow Jesus, Jesus doesn't train him like a dog. He works on his desires, implanting moral vision, giving him new desires. Those new desires winning out over his lesser, sub-Christian desires is what we call discipline. Discipline is doing what we don't necessarily want in order to get what we truly want.

How this works in the realm of physical fitness is obvious. Do you want to have legs like Ronnie Coleman? Then you have to want that more than you want to not be in pain in the gym. Do you want to run a marathon? Then you have to want that more than you want to sit on the couch and watch TV.

In the realm of spiritual or moral fitness, a similar principle applies. Do you want a healthy and fulfilling marriage? Then you have to want that more than you want to watch porn. Do you want a rich spiritual life? Then you have to want to read your Bible and pray more than you want to doomscroll TikTok.

WORKING ON OUR "WANTER"

An animal is not at war within itself; a man is. Man isn't just different from an animal, he's greater than the animals. Evolutionary psychology wants to minimize humans, seeing

them on the same scale as the animals, just further along. Man's self-reflective and self-aware nature is part of what sets him apart and above the other creatures. We speak to ourselves, evaluate ourselves, rebuke ourselves, and inspire ourselves.

The ability to lead yourself is both an asset and a liability, an opportunity and a cause for concern. How many men have led themselves poorly, and in doing so inflicted great pain on their family and friends? How many, convincing themselves they were doing good, ended up rationalizing doing evil?

Many men dream of conquering mountains and building companies, but few seem preoccupied with conquering themselves and building their souls.

There are two moves here: self-evaluation followed by self-leadership. This invitation comes to us from Jesus Himself.

When we first hear Jesus speak in the gospel of John, He gets right to the heart of this. Jesus is walking along the road where John the Baptist was with two of His disciples. John yells out, "Behold! The lamb of God!" When these disciples heard this, they started following Jesus.

Jesus turns to them and asks, "What are you seeking?" That could also be translated, "What are you desiring?" or "What do you want?" Self-evaluation.

It's our first encounter with Jesus in the book of John, and He's interrogating our wants, our desires. In our last encounter with Jesus in the book of John, He's doing the same thing.

In a later episode of John, Jesus asks the women who have gone to look for Him at His tomb, "Who are you seeking?" or "Who do you want?" The what has changed to a who. Maybe before Jesus, the main things you want are sex, money, or power. After meeting Jesus, the main thing you want is Jesus. Do the other desires go away? No, but now they are no longer the primary drivers of our lives.

In the last episode of John, Jesus asks Peter three times, "Do you love me?" Why three? Well, Peter had denied Jesus three times. Why did he deny Jesus? Because, in the moment, he wanted security and acceptability more than he wanted Jesus. Is wanting security a bad thing? No, but wanting it more than we want Jesus is. Peter has been with Jesus for years now—his choice to follow Jesus and be changed over time by Jesus is the most wise thing he's ever done. The most fruitful way to lead yourself is to outsource the ultimate authority you have over yourself to Jesus.

John's gospel is making a clear point: Following Jesus has everything to do with what we want, what we love, and what we desire. Sometimes we call this inner thing our "heart." It's

the center of who we are, the driver of our actions, and the engine that's powering everything from beneath the hood. Another way of saying this is we have a "wanter" that sometimes needs tweaking and other times needs complete overhauling.

Another way of looking at this: "The Lord disciplines the one he loves" (Heb. 12:6). The word for discipline here is *paideuo*, which has the same root as the Greek word for child. It's about education, development, or correction. God's Fatherly presence is helping us properly grow up. Sometimes this discipline is something that is happening to us; sometimes it's something we do to ourselves.

Paul uses the same idea in 1 Corinthians 9:27: "I discipline my body and keep it under control." Here Paul is recognizing that there's a natural direction in him that needs correction, so he's taking proactive measures to adjust himself.

So, whose job is it to discipline us? Ours or God's? Well, both: "Work out your own salvation . . . for it is God who works in you both to will and to work" (Phil. 2:12–13). God works and you work. How exactly this plays out is a mystery, and the Bible isn't all that interested in solving that mystery. God disciplines you and you discipline you.

This is where the dual meaning of the word discipline can be confusing. Sometimes discipline means correction—e.g., when someone gets put on "disciplinary leave" for bad behavior. Other times, the word discipline is more positive, opportunistic even—as in, "I've been able to discipline myself in getting in my ten thousand steps most days."

Discipline has the same root as disciple. A disciple is a student or a learner. Disciplines are processes or behaviors that teach and shape a person in a positive way. They don't have to be correcting a problem—they can be simply improving a weakness. But they always are instruments of discomfort meant to incrementally create change.

INCREASING YOUR PAIN TOLERANCE

The first time I did a cold plunge I had high hopes. My "guide" who owned the cold plunge tank told me that my goal for the first time should be two to three minutes. I asked, "How long do you do it for?" She said, "Five minutes." I responded, "I'll do five minutes."

"Okay." With lifted eyebrows she added, "But you should ease your way in, going up to your waist, and then your chest, and then up to your neck. I recommend keeping your hands out, probably your arms too."

"Sure," I agreed, but I wasn't going to do that. I was going straight in up to my neck, all the way. No half measures.

I told myself it would hurt. *You'll want to get out. Don't. Mind over matter.* I'm generally good at doing hard things.

I eased myself right in up to the neck. The circulating water was 37 degrees. I counted ten deep, slow breaths. Then I started to find out the hard way that I'm an Arizona boy. My elbows were being turned inside out. My knees felt as though I'd been kicked by a horse. Someone was stabbing my forearms with a hot space laser. I told myself, *You knew this would hurt.* Then I told myself, *Idiot, get out of this water immediately.* I went back and forth in my head a thousand times in the span of six seconds and then found myself getting out of the tank. I had made it 87 seconds.

Finding out you're not as tough as you thought you were isn't pleasant. Especially right in front of someone you'd just arrogantly overestimated yourself to. Especially when you just dismissed someone's wisdom right to their face. Especially on your birthday (it was my birthday).

Sometimes shame is a good thing—the feeling of being exposed in a way you didn't plan on or want. You come face-to-face with your limits and discover all at once that you aren't who you thought you were.

It's one thing when it's about something as meaningless as a cold plunge; it's another when it relates to sex, money, or work. To learn the hard way that you need to grow in a way you didn't know you were deficient in. It's like looking in the mirror and realizing you have a zit you didn't know about. A little shock, a little horror.

Here's where I went wrong: I *demand*ed that I be more than I was. I didn't have what it takes. That isn't how people grow or change. Since then, I've been doing less-cold cold plunges, starting around 60 degrees and progressively getting colder and longer. Embracing a deliberate process of incremental change is the way.

This is part of what it means to “become like children” (Matt. 18:3)—to embrace a perpetual state of growth and development.

I used to have a Romanian weightlifting coach named Ištván. He won a medal in the European Championships. He had been training me for a while. After a few years of lifting, I was finally able to clean and jerk 300 pounds. I barely got it, but I was thrilled I'd hit a major milestone. After I completed the lift I turned back to him to share my excitement. He was unenthused. He shrugged. “Sloppy, shaky, just okay,” he said in his thick accent.

I didn't understand. More than a bit frustrated, I asked, "What did I do wrong? What should I do differently?" He said, "ehhhh" and, after a long pause, added, "Three more years and you can be good. Your nervous system is a baby." Tips, strategies, and coaching can't replace years of disciplined practice.

There is no microwaving of growth. Not good growth, anyway. Cancer grows fast; muscles, bones, and neuropath ways grow slowly . . . painfully slowly once you're no longer a child. This is why men need process over product. We tend to look at ourselves, see our deficiencies, desire differently, and then try to summon ourselves into immediate change. Rarely is this how growth works. That approach tends to result in defeat, self-loathing, and unhealthy shame that throws up its hands and says, "I'll never change, so what's the point of even trying?"

The need to grow isn't just the result of sin, but of how God built creation. God made the world rich and good, but in need of development. Adam had to eat in the garden to sustain his life and function, and Jesus Himself had to increase "in wisdom and in stature" (Luke 2:52). While some need for growth involves overcoming sin (for example, like needing to grow in sexual purity), much of it doesn't.

Like an NFL player watches film, so also Christian men evaluate the content of their lives and look for things to celebrate and things to change. Identifying an area in which you need to grow is a positive thing. It moves a deficiency out from the realm of blind spot and into the realm of opportunity.

A MAN'S DOMAINS

A man, being a prince the same way as Adam, is to have dominion over and subdue the creation. But the first thing he must have dominion over is himself. It is appropriate to speak of a man in terms of domain, since a man is delegated jurisdiction over himself by God directly.

Going back to Adam in the garden, we see that Adam's sin had everything to do with his lack of discipline. Genesis 3:6 indicates that Adam was with Eve during the serpent's temptation. He was meant to say no to the serpent and not eat of the fruit, but he lacked the courage or the conviction to do so. Instead of having self-control, he was serpent-controlled. This is where men must learn to think in absolutes: If I will not be controlled by myself, I will be controlled by something else.

This is, again, only a good thing if your self is joined to Christ, conforming to His will, and led by the Spirit. But to even be a self, you must have some form of boundaries— who am I

and who am I not? Just like a house has a door, a man has self-control. There is a mechanism that controls what gets in and what goes out.

“A man without self-control is like a city broken into and left without walls” (Prov. 25:28). When we, like an animal, let our selves run wild instead of imposing constraints on them, we function as well as a military garrison without effective fencing. We’re more vulnerable to ruin than we need to be, and we can’t function as we ought to.

Two key realms in which a man requires discipline are physical and spiritual. Body and soul. Let’s start with the inner life.

SPIRITUAL DISCIPLINES

For thousands of years, God’s people have been practicing spiritual disciplines, which are habits and practices that are designed to form those who do them into men who are connected to God, mentally sharp, and emotionally healthy.

Author and professor Dallas Willard, in *Spirit of the Disciplines*, broke the spiritual disciplines into two categories: disciplines of abstinence (not doing something) and disciplines of engagement (doing something).

Disciplines of Abstinence	Disciplines of Engagement
solitude	study
silence	worship
fasting	celebration
frugality	service
chastity	prayer
secrecy	fellowship
sacrifice	confession
	submission

Here’s my summary of what those practices entail:

Solitude: Withdrawing from others to listen to God in focused stillness.

Silence: Ceasing speech, inputs, and noise for the purpose of self-awareness in the presence of God.

Fasting: Abstaining from food to learn hunger for God.

Frugality: Avoiding excess spending in pursuit of contentedness.

Chastity: Practicing absolute sexual fidelity.

Secrecy: Concealing good deeds to foster humility and rely on feeling seen by God.

Sacrifice: Giving up something valuable to deepen trust in God.

Study: Intentionally examining Scripture and other spiritual books to align our mind with God's mind.

Worship: Attending church and praising God in the presence of other Christ followers.

Celebration: Rejoicing and feasting to honor God's goodness and generosity.

Service: Acting selflessly in contribution to a meaningful cause or to meet others' needs in love.

Prayer: Speaking to God through heartfelt communication and attentive listening.

Fellowship: Investing in meaningful friendships that encourage and sharpen.

Confession: Acknowledging sins openly to God and others.

Submission: Surrendering personal desires to align with God's will and authority.

Some of these disciplines we ought to practice all the time, not just for a season (for example, chastity). Other disciplines we should not do all the time, or we will die (for example, fasting).

Sometimes spiritual disciplines can become legalistic. They can end up being a "taking yourself seriously for God" attitude. These aren't ways of proving your affection for God either to God, to others, or to yourself. These are best done with the goal of connection, exploration, and joy. They are date nights, not business meetings.

I try to practice all of these at least once in the course of a year, but think of them in terms of daily, weekly, monthly, and annual rhythms.

Daily, first thing in the morning after my alarm goes off, I pray before I open my cellphone. Then I open my calendar app and pray for my appointments and responsibilities. I put my phone down and read until I have to go to the bathroom. At night, I dock my cellphone away from my bed at least a half hour before I get to bed, where I spend time with my wife and read until I'm about to fall asleep.

Weekly, I "fast" from my cellphone for twelve hours at least once, eat like a king in celebrating God's blessings once (usually on a date night with my wife, Taylor, or while hosting another

family at our house), attend church every Sunday morning, and ensure our schedule makes space for both my wife and me to serve in a substantial way within the church.

Monthly, we examine our pattern of frugality, curbing lifestyle creep, and make sure our money is going in and out like we want it to. Personally, I work to get at least one three-hour session of silence and solitude in. That one, in particular, when I don't do it, I notice my feelings of overwhelm and general anxiety increase when I skip it. We make space for Taylor to get some type of girls' night in once a month and for me to get time with other men who spur me on to love and good works (more on that in chapter 6).

Annually, I do a weeklong phone/internet fast (while on vacation) and a three-day food fast (not while on vacation!).

Many of the other spiritual disciplines I'll practice as needed. Do I notice that I'm increasingly preoccupied with the opinions of others? I should probably practice secrecy and serve or give in a radical way and tell nobody about it. Is there sin or a pattern of sin I need to confess to someone in particular? Schedule a time and do it. Is there a biblical or theological topic that I really need to dive into in order to faithfully approach a pressing complex issue? Buy a book or two and schedule some additional study time.

Sometimes I'll practice a spiritual discipline and it'll feel like nothing happened and it was a waste of time. But it wasn't a waste of time. Not every date night needs to be Romeo and Juliet-level romance. Not every workout needs to be a crippling marathon. Sometimes going through the motions is okay. After all, the Holy Spirit is like the wind and He comes and goes as He pleases (John 3:8). We are ultimately opening ourselves up to the work of God, not merely engaging in self-improvement.

PHYSICAL DISCIPLINES

The standard modern way of life is hostile to human flourishing. We sit more than ever, eight to ten hours per day for someone with an office job. The average person in a developed nation sits eight hours per day and is overweight. Six in ten have some type of chronic disease. Four in ten have more than one chronic disease. In the last hundred years, we've lost an average of two whole hours of sleep per night.

Who cares? Well, God does, actually. The sixth commandment is "You shall not murder" and the Westminster Confession of Faith, a document written by pastors in the 1600s, applies that commandment to our lives like this:

Question: What are the duties required in the sixth commandment?

Answer: The duties required in the sixth commandment are, all careful studies, and lawful endeavours, to preserve the life of ourselves and others by resisting all thoughts and purposes, subduing all passions, and avoiding all occasions, temptations, and practices, which tend to the unjust taking away the life of any; by just defence thereof against violence, patient bearing of the hand of God, quietness of mind, cheerfulness of spirit; a sober use of meat, drink, physic, sleep, labor, and recreation.

Here's the big idea: Slowly committing suicide by life-style is forbidden by God. Part of our obedience to the sixth commandment includes intentional pursuit of physical health by paying attention to our diet and exercise. This was way less important 150 years ago when about half of the American population lived on farms, and the pattern of ordinary life wasn't radical slothfulness.

Also, the standard American diet (a.k.a. SAD) is simply not good. Highly processed and calorically dense addictive foods don't help men be the best version of themselves. Plus, they can cause premature death. You can't love or serve anyone when you're dead, and your ability to love and serve is severely impaired when you're physically not well. It's one thing when you're dealing with or facing disability or disease that isn't your fault; you play the cards you're dealt. It's another thing when poor stewardship and habits have eroded your ability to function as God has called you to.

While this issue might be more acute in the modern era, it isn't foreign to the world of the Bible. Sloth (resting too much) and gluttony (eating too much) are recognized as issues in the wisdom literature: If you have found honey, eat only enough for you, lest you have your fill of it and vomit it. (Prov. 25:16) Sweet is the sleep of a laborer, whether he eats little or much, but the full stomach of the rich will not let him sleep. (Eccl. 5:12)

The temptation to sloth and gluttony used to only exist for the relatively hyper-wealthy, such as kings, queens, and oligarchs. Now, almost all ordinary people have virtually a limitless access to calories and at least some downtime.

There is a lot of conflicting advice about which diet and exercise habits are the best, but what isn't up for debate is that you need diet and exercise habits that support your well-being in the short- and long-term. God created your body with needs. Give it what it needs. If you want to be healthy in the modern world, you must decide to swim upstream.

THE NEED FOR DELIBERATE PROCESS

After doing CrossFit for ten years, I'd improved in a lot of areas, but my deadlift had been stuck at the same number for *nine straight years*. I was annoyed with this and decided it

was time to change that. In January, on a whim, I told a couple of my friends at the gym, “This year I want to add 75 pounds to my deadlift. That’ll get me to a nice round number.”

One of them responded and said, “Sounds like a fun goal. What’s your strategy for hitting that?” I didn’t have one, so she sent the group text the link to the Wendler 5-3-1 Spread sheet. There are 353 rows and 12 columns. That’s 4,236 boxes. When I looked at it, I felt claustrophobic. But, partly because of social pressure and partially because I actually wanted to improve in the area, it worked. It took six months, but it worked.

The practices of disciplines that are rooted in a process is how God designed us to grow. Eat, work, sleep, and repeat. It’s how children grow and it’s how adults grow. We need to be process-oriented rather than product-oriented in our thinking.